WEEK 3 · LECTURE L2 · UNIT II

Flow, Purpose, and Drive

Optimal experience, the design of work itself, the power of purpose, and an Indian frame of duty in dialogue with Western theory.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Explain the conditions of flow and why work can produce it.
- Apply the job characteristics model to the design of a job.
- Evaluate the evidence that contact with beneficiaries raises effort.
- Compare flow, job design, purpose and nishkama karma as accounts of meaningful work.

COURSE OUTCOMES

CLO 3 (evaluate motivation theories) and CLO 5 (translate them into the design of work).

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

Meaningful work is something HR can give to employees.

Agree or disagree. If HR cannot give it, what can HR do?

THEORY IN DEPTH · CSIKSZENTMIHALYI (1990)

Flow: the psychology of optimal experience

THE CORE IDEA

Flow is complete absorption in an activity, experienced as deeply rewarding in itself.

HOW IT WORKS

It needs clear goals, immediate feedback, and a balance between the challenge and the person's skill.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Studied mostly through self report; it explains moments well and careers less well.

IN PRACTICE

A system that gives feedback once a year removes one condition of flow from everyday work.

EXAM LENS

Use flow to argue for frequent feedback and stretch matched to skill. Weakness: hard to design for at scale.

THE PARADOX OF WORK · CSIKSZENTMIHALYI AND LEFEVRE (1989)

Flow happens at work more than people think

THE FINDING

Experience sampling found flow more often at work than in leisure.

THE PARADOX

Yet people still wished to be doing something else while at work.

KEY POINT

Engagement is not only about the task. How people frame work shapes whether they value the flow it gives.

The job characteristics model

Core dimension	Critical psychological state
Skill variety, task identity, task significance	Experienced meaningfulness
Autonomy	Experienced responsibility for outcomes
Feedback from the job	Knowledge of results

EXAM LENS

Growth need strength moderates the effects. Humphrey et al. (2007) added social characteristics such as interdependence and support.

THEORY IN DEPTH · GRANT ET AL. (2007)

Purpose made concrete

THE CORE IDEA

Contact with the people who benefit from one's work increases motivation and persistence.

HOW IT WORKS

University fundraisers who briefly met a scholarship student spent more time on the phone and raised more money.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Short field experiments in one setting; the effect may fade without renewed contact.

IN PRACTICE

A pharmaceutical plant invites patients to speak to line staff about the medicine they make.

EXAM LENS

Strong evidence that purpose can be designed. Pair it with the job characteristics model on task significance.

POPULAR SYNTHESIS AND ITS LIMITS

Pink, and the meaning of work

PINK (2009)

Autonomy, mastery and purpose: an accessible restatement of self determination and flow.

ROSSO, DEKAS AND WRZESNIEWSKI (2010)

Meaning comes from the self, others, the work context and spiritual life, through distinct mechanisms.

EVIDENCE FIRST

A popular book is a bridge to the research, not a substitute for it.

AN INDIAN FRAME IN DIALOGUE

Nishkama karma and self determination

THE IDEA · BHAGAVAD GITA 2.47

Act fully, without attachment to the fruits of action. Value lies in the act performed as duty.

WHERE IT MEETS SDT

Close to autonomous motivation: the act is endorsed for its own worth, not for reward.

WHERE IT DIFFERS · SINHA (2008)

Grounded in duty in a role, rather than in personal choice.

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

A repetitive machine operator's shift

Theory	Diagnosis	Design it implies
Flow	Challenge below skill; feedback delayed	Raise challenge; give immediate feedback
Job characteristics	Low task identity and feedback	Enlarge the task; feedback from the job
Prosocial purpose	No contact with who benefits	Connect operators to customers
Nishkama karma	Meaning located in the duty itself	Honor craft and role, not only output

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"Purpose cannot be managed; it can only be found." Critically evaluate using flow, job design and prosocial motivation. **20 marks**

A strong answer: explains each theory; uses Grant et al. as evidence that purpose can be designed; notes limits; applies to an Indian firm.

Compare Pink's account of motivation with self determination theory and the job characteristics model. **20 marks**

A strong answer: shows Pink restates SDT; contrasts job design mechanisms; evaluates evidence quality; reaches a reasoned view.

State the conditions for flow at work. **10 marks**

A strong answer: clear goals, immediate feedback, challenge matched to skill; one workplace example.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. Flow needs clear goals, immediate feedback and challenge matched to skill
2. Meaning can be designed into jobs through identity, significance and contact with beneficiaries
3. Indian frames of duty can sit alongside self determination as equally serious accounts

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

Deci, E. L., & Ryan, R. M. (2008). Self determination theory: A macrotheory of human motivation, development, and health. *Canadian Psychology, 49*(3), 182–185.

Csikszentmihalyi, M. (1990). *Flow: The psychology of optimal experience*. Harper & Row. Chapters 1 to 2.

Pink, D. H. (2009). *Drive: The surprising truth about what motivates us*. Riverhead Books. Chapters 1 to 3.

Luthans, F., Youssef, C. M., & Avolio, B. J. (2007). *Psychological capital: Developing the human competitive edge*. Oxford University Press. Chapter 1.

HOW TO USE THESE

These are the Week 3 set readings. Csikszentmihalyi (1990) and Pink (2009) are the core readings for this lecture.

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

Sources for this lecture (1 of 3)

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Bhagavad Gita, Chapter 2, verse 47.

Csikszentmihalyi, M. (1990). *Flow: The psychology of optimal experience*. Harper & Row.

Csikszentmihalyi, M., & LeFevre, J. (1989). Optimal experience in work and leisure. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 56*(5), 815–822. https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.56.5.815

Grant, A. M., Campbell, E. M., Chen, G., Cottone, K., Lapedis, D., & Lee, K. (2007). Impact and the art of motivation maintenance: The effects of contact with beneficiaries on persistence behavior. *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes, 103*(1), 53–67. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.obhdp.2006.05.004

Sources for this lecture (2 of 3)

Hackman, J. R., & Oldham, G. R. (1976). Motivation through the design of work: Test of a theory. *Organizational Behavior and Human Performance, 16*(2), 250–279. https://doi.org/10.1016/0030-5073(76)90016-7

Humphrey, S. E., Nahrgang, J. D., & Morgeson, F. P. (2007). Integrating motivational, social, and contextual work design features: A meta analytic summary and theoretical extension of the work design literature. *Journal of Applied Psychology, 92*(5), 1332–1356. https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.92.5.1332

Pink, D. H. (2009). *Drive: The surprising truth about what motivates us*. Riverhead Books.

Sources for this lecture (3 of 3)

Rosso, B. D., Dekas, K. H., & Wrzesniewski, A. (2010). On the meaning of work: A theoretical integration and review. *Research in Organizational Behavior, 30*, 91–127. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.riob.2010.09.001

Sinha, J. B. P. (2008). *Culture and organizational behaviour*. Sage.